

LIGHT COIN

*A game of silver, short weight,
and a currency everybody needs and nobody trusts*

5 PLAYERS • 12 ROUNDS • 75 MINUTES

*No single light coin can be told from a good one.
No single light coin makes anybody poorer.
The coinage fails all the same.*

1 The Coin

Your city mints its own money, and each of the five great Houses holds the right to strike it. A coin is worth what it weighs in silver, and it passes from hand to hand all day long because everybody trusts that it does.

You can strike a light coin. A little less silver, the same face stamped on it, the difference too small for anybody to feel in their palm. Every House can do this, and the profit is immediate.

One light coin harms nobody. Nor does a hundred. But coin circulates, and light coin circulates faster, and there comes a point at which the traders begin weighing rather than counting, and then refusing altogether. When that happens the money is worthless in every purse in the city, including yours.

The difficulty is that a purse of coin tells you how much silver is missing but never which House it came from, nor whether your own full-weight striking on any particular day was the thing that kept the money good.

The shape of the game

You win by accumulating Profit, and striking light is the fastest way to accumulate it. But if Trust reaches zero before the twelfth round, *every player loses, including whoever was winning*. The game is an argument about how much bad silver the city can absorb, conducted by people who cannot check each other's work.

2 Components

55 white coins	A coin struck full weight. One per House each round.
70 black coins	A coin struck light. One per House each round. <i>See the note below: the two counts differ on purpose.</i>
1 Till bag	Opaque. The day's coin goes in here.
1 Silver bag	Emptied and counted out afresh, 16 white and 4 black, each round.
5 cups	Opaque. Conceals your retained striking coin.
5 jars	Opaque, lidded. Your striking record. Never opened until the end. <i>Coins, not cubes: same diameter, so nobody can tell them apart by touch in the bag.</i>
5 screens	Or simply play below the table edge.
Trust track	0 to 40, with 21 marked clearly. That is the Turn.
1 round log	A shared sheet. Everything public gets written down.
20 Discredit tokens	Red. Kept in public view.
5 player aids	The challenge table, reproduced at the back.
1 First Player marker	Passes clockwise each round.

Why 70 black and only 55 white

One coin per House is locked into a jar each round and never comes back, which is sixty over a full game, on top of the thirty in circulation.

Which colour gets locked away depends on how the table plays, and the two cases are not symmetric. You retain *black* when you strike full weight, so an honest table buries five black coins a round and needs about seventy. A table that clips heavily would bury white instead, but it also destroys the coinage by around round six, so it never gets through more than about fifty.

Sixty of each would run out on an honest table, which is the commonest way for a game to go. Seventy of each is fine if you would rather not count two different numbers.

3 Setup

1. Set the Trust marker to 36.

2. Give each player one white and one black coin, one cup, one jar, one screen and one player aid.
3. Put 16 white and 4 black coins in the Silver bag. Leave the Till empty.
4. Nobody scores anything yet. Profit is not paid out during the game; it is reconstructed at the end. Rule up the round log with a column for each round.
5. Give the First Player marker to whoever most recently signed something without reading it.

4 The Round

Twelve rounds, five phases each. The first two matter more than they look, because they are what stops anybody working out who did what.

Phase 1. The Striking

Behind your screen, take one white and one black coin in a closed fist. The Till passes in seat order. Reach in, release *exactly one* coin, and withdraw your fist still closed.

Release black to strike light. Release white to strike full weight.

Then, in full view, place the coin still in your hand under your cup without showing it. That retained coin is the exact opposite of the one you played, and it is now the only proof of what you did.

Do this before you touch the Silver bag

Both coins must be committed, one in the till and one under the cup, before anybody draws silver. A player still holding a coin when the silver comes round can swap the two, and a House that struck light has every reason to gamble on it.

Phase 2. The Silver

The Silver bag holds sixteen white coins and four black. It passes in seat

order.

Reach in, take *one coin without looking at it*, and drop it straight into the Till with your hand closed.

You will never know what you contributed. Neither will anybody else. Roughly one round in five your silver came in adulterated, and there is no arrangement under which you could have refused it, declared it, or been believed about it afterwards.

Why you are not allowed to look

If you knew what you had drawn, you would have every reason to hold the black back and put a white coin in instead. Bad silver erodes Trust, and Trust is your money. Every House would reason the same way, no adulterated metal would ever reach the till, and with it would go the uncertainty that makes an assay a judgement rather than an arithmetic exercise.

Phase 3. The Count

Tip out the Till. Count the black coins aloud. That number is the round's Light Count.

It counts both deliberate short weight and bad silver nobody ordered, and there is no way to tell how the total divides between them.

Phase 4. The Assay

Before the Turn: beginning with the First Player and going clockwise, the first player who wishes to may call one assay, and only one is called per round in total. After the Turn, *every* House that struck full weight may call one, each on a different target.

You may only call an assay if you released a white striking coin this round.

Name a House and demand their coin on the scales. They lift their cup.

Light White under the cup means they played black. They lose this round's Profit and take a Discredit. The challenger gains 3 Profit.

Sound Black under the cup means they struck full weight. *The challenger* takes a Discredit.

A House taking its third Discredit is ruined and out of the game.

Why only the honest may accuse

You cannot demand that others put their coin on the scales in a round in which your own was short. Policing therefore has a price: to be able to call an assay at all, you must give up the round's larger payout.

Phase 5. Erosion and Reset

Reduce Trust by the Light Count.

Then, without showing it to anybody, drop your retained striking coin into your jar and replace the lid. It is black if you struck full weight this round and white if you struck light, and it went under the cup before you touched anything else, so it cannot be anything but the truth.

Now empty everything into the supply and mix it: the till, and *the Silver bag as well*. Only then count out a fresh sixteen white and four black for the Silver bag, and hand one white and one black to each player. Pass the First Player marker clockwise.

Empty the Silver bag, do not top it up

Twenty coins go into the Silver bag and five come out, which leaves fifteen whose colours depend entirely on what was drawn. Topping the bag back up to sixteen and four would preserve that residue for anybody who glanced into it. Tip the whole thing into the supply, mix, and count out a new twenty.

Why nothing is paid out during the game

Striking light scores and striking full weight does not, so reaching for your money would tell the table exactly what you had done. Nobody takes Profit during a round. Everything public goes on the round log, your one private choice goes into your jar, and the two are put together at the end when secrecy no longer costs anything.

Your jar must hold exactly twelve coins at the close, one for each round. A jar holding any other number has been tampered with.

The round log

One player keeps it, in full view, and everybody can correct it. Each round, record: the Light Count, the new Trust total, who called an assay, whom they named, and what was found. Mark the round in which the coinage turns, since the assay rules change from that point on.

Every one of those is something the whole table watched happen. Only your own striking stays private, and only until the last round is over.

5 Profit

Nothing is paid out during the game. Every striking is worth something, but you collect none of it until the jars come out at the end.

What you did	Coin in jar	Worth
Struck full weight	black	0
Struck light	white	1

The coin is the opposite of what you did
You played one coin and kept the other, so the coin in your jar is always the reverse of your striking. Black in the jar means you were honest. It catches everybody out at least once, so read the left-hand column, not the colour.

Striking light is worth one point more than striking sound, every round, from first to last. Honest work scores nothing at all, which is exactly the difficulty: the only way to get ahead is to clip, and the only way everybody keeps what they have is if hardly anybody does.

A House that clips once and is never assayed has gained one point. A House that clips every round has gained twelve, which wins games comfortably, and has also handed the table eleven more chances to catch it.

6 The Turn

The first time Trust falls below 21, the coinage has turned. Write the round

on the log and announce it.

Nothing about Profit changes. What changes is scrutiny.

Open season

Before the Turn, one assay per round, claimed by the first House who wants it. After the Turn, every House that struck full weight may call an assay, each naming a different target, all in the same round. Traders have begun weighing rather than counting, and a House that keeps clipping is now doing so in front of four sets of scales instead of one.

This is why a failing coinage tends either to recover sharply or to die very fast. Nobody’s payoff has moved. The odds of getting away with it have.

7 Reading the Count

You know the Light Count, and you know whether your own striking coin was black. Subtract it if so. The result is the Remainder, which contains the other four Houses’ strikings and all five silver draws, including your own unknown one.

Remainder	Chance any given House lied
1	19%
2	37%
3	52%
4	65%
5	76%
6	84%

A Remainder of 4 or more and an assay is a good bet on the odds alone. At 2 or 3 it is roughly break-even for you personally.

Assay at 2 and 3 anyway.

Policing is not free, and somebody has to do it

A House that clips once or twice and is never assayed will win, and the Light Count it produces looks entirely innocent: two coins, three at most, exactly what an unlucky round of silver looks like. Nobody has grounds to accuse anybody. That is the trap. If every House waits for a Remainder of 4 before risking an accusation, the careful clipper is never touched and takes the game. Calling an assay on a 2 costs you personally and benefits everybody, which is precisely why it does not happen by itself.

Remember that a bad shipment of silver puts a black coin in the till exactly as deliberate short weight does. A House that was sold adulterated metal is indistinguishable from one that clipped its coin on purpose, and can never prove otherwise.

8 Ending the Game

The game ends after the twelfth round, or immediately if Trust reaches 0.

If the coinage collapses, every player loses, including any who were eliminated earlier and any who were comfortably ahead.

Otherwise, open the jars. Everybody tips theirs out at the same time.

Everything from here is public, and nothing has to be taken on anybody's word. Count each player's white coins. That is one point each, and the black ones are worth nothing.

Black coin You struck full weight. 0.

White coin You struck light. 1.

Caught Minus 6 for each time you were assayed and found light. Ruinous, and meant to be: one catch wipes out six clean rounds of clipping.

Assays 3 for each one you called correctly.

Highest total wins. A player eliminated by Discredits scores nothing, whatever is in their jar.

On winning

Nobody knows the scores until the jars come out, which is the point.

There are two ways to win and they look nothing alike. One is to clip half a dozen times and never be caught. The other is to strike honestly throughout and land two good assays, which is worth the same six points and carries none of the risk of ruin.

What never wins is honest and passive. Striking full weight scores nothing by itself. If you will not clip and will not accuse, you have spent twelve rounds keeping the coinage sound for somebody else to win with.

9 Other Numbers of Houses

The game is written for five. It works from three to six, but two things must change, because the fewer of you there are, the faster a single clipper ruins everybody.

Houses	3	4	5	6
Trust starts at	20	32	34	36
The Turn, at Trust	12	19	20	21
White coins	40	48	55	66
Black coins	45	58	70	84

Everything else is unchanged: one coin of each colour to every House each round, sixteen white and four black in the Silver bag whatever the count, one assay per round before the Turn and open season after it.

Why Trust falls so far at three

With five Houses the coinage survives one clipper and is even money to survive two. With three, two clippers out of three would be a rout, so the knife-edge has to sit at one. Twenty is the number at which a single House clipping every round kills the city at about the twelfth, which is where you want it: the whole game is then an argument about whether anybody is doing it.

Reading the count

The odds change sharply with the number of opponents. Use the column

for your game.

Remainder	3 Houses	4	5	6
1	36%	25%	19%	15%
2	65%	47%	37%	30%
3	82%	65%	52%	43%
4	93%	78%	65%	55%
5	—	88%	76%	65%
6	—	—	84%	74%

At three Houses an assay is a far better bet than at six, for the plain reason that there are fewer people the bad coin could have come from. Three-House games are consequently vicious and short on secrets. Six-House games are the opposite: it is easy to hide, hard to accuse, and the coinage usually dies of ordinary indifference rather than anybody’s malice.

PLAYER AID

The round

1. Striking. Fist into the till, release one. Retained coin under the cup *now*.
2. Silver. One coin from the Silver bag, *unseen*, straight into the till.
3. Count. Black coins aloud.
4. Assay. One only, and only if you struck full weight.
5. Erosion. Trust drops by the Count. Retained coin into your *jar*, lid on.

Reading the count

Remainder = Light Count minus your own striking coin, if it was black.

Remainder	1	2	3	4	5	6
3 Houses	36%	65%	82%	93%	—	—
4 Houses	25%	47%	65%	78%	88%	—
5 Houses	19%	37%	52%	65%	76%	84%
6 Houses	15%	30%	43%	55%	65%	74%

4 or more: a good bet. 2 or 3: break even, and assay anyway.

At the cup

WHITE under the cup	they played black. They lied.
BLACK under the cup	they struck full weight.

Payouts

You	Jar	Worth
struck full weight	black	0
struck light	white	1

The coin in your jar is the opposite of what you struck.

The Turn (Trust below 21): every honest House may assay, not just one.

Assay correctly: +3 to you, a Discredit to them.

Assay wrongly: the Discredit is yours. Three and you are ruined.

Caught light: -6.